

Digital binoculars

Sony has unveiled a pair of binoculars with IS, auto focus and HD video. We await the announcement in India

Sloooooooooooooooooow motion!

The Phantom v1610 video camera shoots a resolution of 128 x 16 pixels at 1 million fps, and 1280 x 720 at over 18,000 fps. Viewing at 30fps, you'll take 10 minutes to view one second of 720p content!

dSLRs Comparison Test

In our high ISO tests, once again, the Sony A33 disappointed with more smearing of textures, colour and details at ISO 800 and above. The Canon 1100D is shockingly less noisier at ISO 800 than its costlier sibling, the 600D, but very slightly so. However, the 600D is still more detailed, and textures are more evident on the 600D. The D3100 cannot handle noise too well, while the output is mostly clean, some smearing of details is visible, and the 1100D is better in this respect. The D5100 does show a bit of noise, but also shows a lot of detail. However, the 600D is a bit better than the D5100 in terms of finer details. In fact, at ISO 1600, it is actually more detailed than the 7D.

At ISO 1600, the Nikon D5100 displays a bit of chroma noise while the output from the 600D is free from this. Both cameras are fairly close, but the 600D just eases ahead. At ISO 1600, the 1100D and the D3100 are about equal, the former shows less noise, while having a softer output, while the D3100 has a little more of noise, but shows a bit more detail. Surprisingly, the output from all these cameras, including the A33 is quite pleasant at this sensitivity, as long as you don't work with close to 100 per cent crops.

And the winner is

All considered, the D5100 offers a lot for the money – full HD recording, a great sensor capable of much detail and rugged body. It won our Digit Best Buy award after carefully considering all the facts and numbers. The D3100 and Sony A33 also make very good buys and came up with identical value scores, a little behind the D5100. In fact, with full HD recording, a new menu and mirror system, the A33

offers a tremendously detailed output at up to ISO 400, and is mostly grain free till ISO 800. It bagged the Editor's Pick.

ENTHUSIAST DSLRS

For many, this will be the most interesting category. These cameras typically offer improved ergonomics and better image quality with larger, more rugged bodies that are just about better in every way. Many pros in India, who do not need the higher-end full frame dSLRs, actually use cameras in this segment for their work. We received four cameras in this price category two from Canon – the EOS 60D, 7D and one each from Nikon (D7000) and Olympus (E5).

Canon EOS 60D: ₹65,295 (body only)

The EOS 60D is a well-built dSLR that exudes a quality feel in hand. It has a nice ergonomic grip and an articulating LCD, as well as an 18 MP sensor derived from the 7D. It isn't as well built as the 7D, and is slightly smaller, but has almost the same button layout, with dual dials and a status LCD. However, the buttons on the left of the LCD have moved to the right, to accommodate the articulating LCDs mechanism. The buttons near the status LCD feel clicky, and are set flush in the body, making them a little less intuitive. The 60D isn't weather sealed. The Nikon D7000 feels better built, with slightly tighter shut lines.

The ergonomics of the 60D are a bit questionable, with play and delete buttons being located on opposite ends of the camera. The 4-way joystick seen on the 7D and 5D Mark 2 has been moved and is inset in the rear dial. With its 9 cross point focussing system, the 60D focuses fast, but the focus points feel a bit sparse, and are

not configurable. We prefer the focussing of the D7000 and the 7D. The LCD on the 60D is a bit sharper than the 7D, but the difference isn't very noticeable.

At base ISOs, the 60D offers a clean, detailed output. The colours are punchy, and there's a lot of detail. There's no noise at ISO 400, and just a little at ISO 800. We noticed the 60D trying just a bit harder to remove noise and therefore there is a little loss of detail. The D7000 in contrast offers even less noise, while maintaining more detail and higher dynamic range, noticeable in the quality of the highlights it produces. At ISO 1600, the 60D's output is largely clean and noise free, but more detail is lost. ISO 800 and 1600 show similar levels of noise – a very good result. At ISO 3200 there is



Canon EOS 600D

some chroma noise visible, but the output is still largely clean. The effects of some ham-handed noise control is visible however, as more detail is lost and textures appear a bit flat. ISO 6400 shows a lot of chroma noise in 100 per cent crops along with some loss of detail, but when viewed at a normal size, the output is still quite punchy and pleasing.

Nikon D7000: ₹59,450 (body only)

The replacement for the D90, the D7000 actually has more in

common with the D300s, with a partial magnesium alloy body, a 39-point focussing system with 9 cross points. However, in terms of its look, it looks more like the D90 and is a size smaller than the D300s and the 7D, with less rubber on the grip, but in hand, it feels extremely solid partially on account of its smaller size. The control layout is similar to the D300s, with some differences. There's no ring for metering, and the focus switch has just 2 modes instead of 3, the third being continuous focus that can be activated via the rear dial. There is also no switch for setting the auto-focus area and points like the D300s. The status LCD is smaller than the D300s and less detailed. The drive mode dial is located beneath the menu dial and is locked against accidental usage with a small button. A dedicate video mode switch is a welcome addition.

Finally, we see 2 card slots – very useful since the D7000 allows both slots to be configured in a number of ways – image + video, JPEG + RAW or as a backup. One minus compared to the 7D is the D7000 doesn't allow fast configuring of the focus points, and with the 7D you can select any one point or group them.

The D7000 focuses really fast, accurately and it captures a lot of detail. At base ISOs, the D7000's output is very clean, with great highlights, better than the 7D and 60D. At ISO 800, there is minimal noise, and little difference at ISO 200. The D7000 controls noise reasonably well at ISO 1600, and maintains more detail than the 7D and 60D that have a softer output. At ISO 3200, the D7000 is sharp, although highlights take a toss, but noise is still well controlled. At ISO 6400, the D7000 begins to lose its composure and noise